Contradiction Memo-Nairuti Vora

1. Statement of Team Assumption

The product development team initially hypothesized that an AI-native conversational chatbot interface is the optimal primary medium for driving student financial engagement, user retention, and daily spending guidance. We presumed that natural language queries, conversational nudges, and gamified personalities (such as automated "roasts") would minimize friction and sustain long-term app usage.

2. Empirical Contradiction & Research Findings

Primary research and competitor teardowns (Artifacts LOG-01, LOG-02, LOG-03) directly contradict this premise. While conversational AI drives initial novelty, it introduces severe operational friction during real-time spending decisions, causing rapid longitudinal engagement decay.

- Point-of-Purchase Friction: Entering chat prompts (e.g., *"Can I afford this?"*) introduces excessive steps and cognitive overhead during time-sensitive transactions, such as standing in line at a store.
- Novelty Degradation: User interviews reveal that humorous conversational features lose their appeal within 30 days, devolving into structural inefficiencies for routine financial checks.
- Demand for Zero-Click Visibility: Users strongly favor passive, immediate visual metrics over active text-based dialogues for everyday budgeting.

3. Strategic Recommendations

To resolve this contradiction and mitigate user churn, I advise the following strategic pivots:

1. Adopt a Visual-First Interaction Architecture: Replace primary chat workflows with a zero-click, prominent "Safe-to-Spend" dashboard widget that displays immediate metric visibility upon app launch.
2. Reposition Conversational AI Asynchronously: Restrict the AI chatbot strictly to asynchronous, high-value tasks—such as weekly financial summaries and goal setup—rather than synchronous micro-decisions.
3. Prioritize Automated Background Mechanics: Reallocate engineering resources toward systemic features that autonomously reduce cognitive load, specifically Smart Auto-Categorization and the AI Mid-Month Auto-Balancer.

Contradiction Memo – Francisco Vazquez

1. Statement of Team Assumption

Our team initially assumed that providing students with detailed spending reports and financial summaries would be enough to help them manage their budgets. We believed that students could review their financial information, identify overspending, and make adjustments on their own when necessary.

2. Empirical Contradiction & Research Findings

The competitor research challenged this assumption. The Monarch Money findings (LOG-02) showed that a participant wanted more proactive budgeting guidance throughout the month rather than relying primarily on financial tracking and dashboards.

Although Monarch Money provides comprehensive financial tracking and AI assistance, the participant expressed a need for recommendations before overspending occurs. This finding suggests that simply showing users their financial information may not be enough to help them stay within their budgets. Students could benefit from guidance that helps them recognize potential financial problems early instead of discovering them after they have already spent too much.

3. Strategic Recommendations

Based on these findings, I recommend the following improvements:

1. Introduce an AI Mid-Month Auto-Balancer: Provide personalized recommendations throughout the month to help students adjust their budgets before overspending occurs.
2. Prioritize Proactive Financial Guidance: Focus on helping students identify potential spending problems early rather than relying only on reports of past transactions.
3. Make Recommendations Actionable: Present clear suggestions that students can use to adjust their spending habits and make better financial decisions.

Contradiction Memo – Hector Pariente

1. Statement of Team Assumption

Our team initially assumed users would be willing to spend a few minutes of their time not only checking their finances and transactions, but also would be open to review and correct their transactions to maintain an accurate reflection of their budget and spending habits.

2. Empirical Contradiction & Research Findings

During our research, LOG-03 for YNAB provided information that the former user reported abandoning the application because the correction of transactions and catching up on missed entries became an overwhelming task. This information suggests that manual budgeting requirements could cause discouragement towards the continued use of the financial application.

3. Strategic Recommendations

Based on the available information provided by our research, I came to the conclusion that user engagement can be better achieved by prioritising automatic transaction categorization and allowing them to review only the transactions that the system flags as requiring attention. By focusing resources on improving the system capabilities for automatic detection of important information, users can leave the identification process to CampusCents. Through these considerations, the application would reduce manual work and make budgeting easier to maintain.

Another recommendation can be the introduction of a feature that allows students to quickly catch up on missed transactions after a period of inactivity. As LOG-03 showed, falling behind on transaction updates made budgeting overwhelming and was an important reason that contributed to the user abandoning the application. Therefore, to solve this issue, Instead of reviewing every transaction individually, CampusCents would provide a summary of recent spending and allow users to make adjustments as needed.

Contradiction Memo – Kinley Tenzin

1. Statement of Team Assumption

In our Sprint 2 business case, the main value of CampusCents is organization and convenience. This is based on the assumption that students would be motivated to use the app consistently, if it would give them expenses, budgets and financial targets all in one simple app.

2. Empirical Contradiction & Research Findings

Findings on the competitive landscape hint convenience may not be enough. The Cleo participant reported that the chat interaction was inconvenient for quick spending decisions (LOG-01). The Monarch Money participant requested advice before spending too much (LOG-02), and the former YNAB user stopped using the application because it became too much to keep up with transactions (LOG-03). The results indicate that consolidating financial information in a single location does not completely resolve the problem of the effort required to monitor a budget or determine the next steps. The business case must describe how CampusCents will reduce that effort and help students act on their financial information.

3. Strategic Recommendations

In light of these findings, I recommend revising the business case to link its expected value directly to the problems identified in our research.

focus on pupils make clear Maintain the business case's focus on students as the primary audience to keep the project tied to the research that supported the original strategy.

Link Features to Business Value: The Safe-to-Spend widget helps you make quick decisions, Smart Auto-Categorization reduces manual work, and the AI Mid-Month Auto-Balancer gives you early tips.

Intensify the GO Recommendation: These research findings should underpin the recommendation and identify what still needs to be validated, including whether the proposed features reduce budgeting effort and help students make timely spending adjustments.